Mapping Our Erotic Blueprint Conversation #1

INSTRUCTIONS: Write 1 - 3 sentences about your experiences and internalizations for each of the questions below. Answering these questions will help you begin to map your erotic blueprint. These are simple questions with complex answers. Pay attention to the questions that you grapple with, and those that mean something important to you.

1. What are two key messages about *relationships* that I received from my family/community?

    1.)

    2.)

2. What are two key messages about *sex & sexuality* that I received from my family/community?

    1.)

    2.)

3. What are two key messages about *men and women* that I received from my family and community/culture?

    1.)

    2.)

4. Did I learn to safely trust the people in my family/community?

5. What was the role of pleasure in my family?

6. Where did I learn to love, and how?

7. Did my parent(s)/caregiver(s) monitor my needs, or was I expected to monitor

theirs?

8. Did I feel accepted by my family/community?

9. Did I learn to take risks, and was I encouraged to thrive?

10. How did I learn to handle my emotions when I was upset?

Mapping Our Erotic Blueprint Conversation #2

INSTRUCTIONS: This list of questions gives you a framework to engage in sexual conversations with yourself and with your partner. I want you to think broadly when exploring the meaning, aspirations, blocks, likes and dislikes around your sexuality. I encourage you to be self aware and to open up communication. The questions span biographical cues, emotional and physical responses, solo sex and partner sex. *This is a template. You need not follow them in order, nor do you need to answer all. There is no right and wrong. Some questions are relevant to you, and others are not.*

1. What does sex mean to you?

2. A person that strongly influenced you sexually is _____ ?

3. An event that strongly influenced your sexuality is _____ ?

4. What aspects of your sexual life do you value and would you like to keep/harness/hold on to?

5. What aspect of your sexual life would you like to let go off/leave behind/change?

6. What is erotic for you?

7. When do you feel most free?

8. When do you feel most attractive?

9. Is there something sexual you long for?

10. What's a sexual dilemma for you?

11. What is a vulnerability around your sexuality that you struggle with?

12. Are there things in your sexuality that scare you?

13. What's forbidden for you sexually?

14. Is there a barrier you'd like to cross?

15. What do you like to experience in sex (circle the answer(s) that apply to you)?

Tenderness Softness Closeness Intensity Aggression To be taken A spiritual connection Rebellious A release Surrender Dominance Abandon Freedom Free from any responsibility Ruthlessness Timelessness A state of transcendence Giving Receiving To possess

16. What do you enjoy most when you make love?

17. Do you initiate sex? How do you respond when your partner initiates?

18. Do you react when your partner refuses sex?

19. Do you ever introduce new ideas in your sexual relationship?

20. How comfortable are you communicating your sexual wants or dislikes?

Mapping Our Erotic Blueprint
Conversation #2 (continued)

21. When you are bored sexually, what do you do to change that?

22. What is more difficult for you: to think and talk about sex OR to do it?

23. What turns you off sexually?

24. What turns you on sexually?

25. Do you like to look at your partner and be seen when you make love?

26. Do you want sexual exclusiveness in your relationships?

27. Is there anything, physical or emotional, that you feel during solo sex that you wish you felt during partnered sex?

28. How do you like to be touched? (Do you know how you like to be touched?)

29. How does your body respond when you get erotic? (for example: relaxed? freeze? open?)

30. Have you been hurt in love?

31. Have you hurt someone in love?

32. Have you ever been hurt sexually?

33. Do you like to make love to yourself?

34. Who are you as a lover?

35. How does your partner experience you as a sexual partner? 36. Do you touch yourself when you have sex with your partner?

37. What is the role of religion in your life, and how does it influence your sexuality (beliefs, attitudes, behaviors?)

38. Among the five senses, which one is the most sexual for you? Seeing, Smelling, Hearing, Touching, or Tasting?

39. Do you invite fantasy in your sexuality

Mapping Our Erotic Blueprint: Actionable #1

This week, you will initiate something new and different in your relationship with a clear purpose to expand the erotic and the intimate. It can be as small as bringing coffee to your partner in bed, sending a sexy message, or planning a surprise trip. Do something that is out of your comfort zone and your routine.

If you find that you have been overly other-focused, to the detriment of yourself, put the focus on you. Do something for yourself/with yourself that is outside of the typical that makes you feel alive and vibrant. If you are solo at this time in your life, it is no different. Allow yourself to stay in bed an hour later, get a massage, sit in the sun, watch your body while you shower. Do something that increases your awareness of yourself and what is pleasurable to you.

If you are willing to own up to your self-centeredness, be sure to put the focus on your partner. Stretch and reach beyond your limits, and make yourself present and available. The effort is what matters here. If you are not sure where to start, use the past exercises as a jumping off point. Be playful. Be fresh. Be rule-busting. Be naughty. Be curious.

Mapping Our Erotic Blueprint Conversation #3

INSTRUCTIONS: In each section, jot down words, images, and associations that come to mind. Fill in all of column LOVE first. Go down the entire left side before moving over to the SEXUALITY column. Make sure you have this sheet in front of you for your conversation.

LOVE	SEXUALITY
When I think of love, I think of:	When I think of sex, I think of:
When I love I feel:	When I desire I feel:
When I am loved I feel:	When I am desired I feel:
When I think of love between my partner and me today, I feel:	When I think about sex between my partner and me, I feel:

Mapping Our Erotic Blueprint Conversation #4: Boundaries

DIRECTIONS: To communicate your personal boundaries and expectations to a partner, you must first understand them. In a world where intimacy and connection is fluid and vague, how do you negotiate privacy and transparency? Think about and write answers to the questions below. You may currently not be in a relationship. Apply the questions to previous relationships and interactions with partners. I encourage you to be self aware and honest in your answers.

1.Write down 5 sexual boundaries (physical, emotional, mental and/or spiritual) that are important to you (for example: I expect my partner to not meet women alone, I do not want any anal penetration, I want to know my partner's sexual fantasies, etc).

1.
2.
3.
4.
5.

2. I would describe the conversations around sexual boundaries with my partner as:
❑ honest ❑ dangerous ❑ deceitful ❑ unclear ❑ a set up ❑ respectful ❑ honoring of our bond ❑ clearly defined ❑ exciting

CIRCLE ONE NUMBER ON THE SCALE OF 1 - 5

3. I have open conversations about sexual boundaries with my partners.
NOT AT ALL 1 2 3 4 5 VERY MUCH

4. I have defined what fidelity means in my relationship with my partner.
NOT AT ALL 1 2 3 4 5 VERY MUCH

5. I discuss the nature of sexual exclusiveness or consensual non-monogamy with my partner.
NOT AT ALL 1 2 3 4 5 VERY MUCH

6. I am transparent about my digital communications with others.
NOT AT ALL 1 2 3 4 5 VERY MUCH

7. I make room for jealousy.
NOT AT ALL 1 2 3 4 5 VERY MUCH

8. In my relationships, I have a practice of revisiting the monogamy agreement.
NOT AT ALL 1 2 3 4 5 VERY MUCH

WRITE 1-5 SENTENCES FOR EACH

9. My experience of trust in my relationship (currently or past) has been:

10. Have your boundaries ever been crossed? What was that experience like for you?

Mapping Our Erotic Blueprint Conversation #5: Security & Adventure

DIRECTIONS: Look inward. You can close your eyes, if it helps you go inside .

Think of one moment in your life when you felt safe, secure and deeply anchored. Perhaps you were alone, or with family and friends. It could be, for example, when you were spending a weekend with your 3 best friends, holding a baby in your arms, crying to a friend who has your back, sitting by the bedside of your dying grandparent or after making love.

What is one emotion that captures that experience?

Where do you feel this emotion in your body?

Now walk to the other side of the spectrum of life. Think of a moment when experienced adventure, curiosity, openness and vulnerability. For example, when you are eating with full awareness, washing your body while actually looking at it, expressing a desire for someone or conquering a fear.

What is the main emotion that accompanies this feeling for you?

Where do you feel this emotion in your body?

Now, in one word, image or metaphor, describe yourself when you are at your most authentic:

Mapping Our Erotic Blueprint Conversation #6: Action Six Intimacy Verbs

DIRECTIONS: There are six intimacy verbs that every couple should have in their vocabulary in order to have a more satisfying relationship. Write down one request for each of the verbs below. Over the next two weeks, take one day to experiment with each. Each day focus on one verb to talk about with your partner.

1. **ASK** Think about one thing you want to ask your partner. It could be anything from asking for a longer kiss to requesting that she move a little slower. When your partner does what you ask of them it is important to tell them how it makes you feel.

2. **TAKE** Write down one thing that you want to take from your partner that gives you pleasure. An example would be how running your fingers through his hair makes you feel good while doing the same for him.

3. **GIVE** Write down something you want to give to your partner that will bring them pleasure.

4. **RECEIVE** It's really important to receive what your partner offers you.

5. **REFUSE** Write down one thing you want to refuse.

6. **SHARE** What would you like to share with your partner emotionally or physically?

Mapping our Erotic Blueprint Conversation #7: Trust, Empathy & Emotional Intimacy

It's not the amount of conflict that determines the quality of your relationship, but your capacity for repair. Building trust between two people and and releasing pain inflicted on one another are both two way streets. When your relationship is in distress, it's more difficult to recognize the legitimacy of the other's feelings and maintain an empathic connection. Very often, what destroys the sexual safety, is that we lose our ability to see the other person as an entire entity, separate from us (not just thinking about how what you're doing affects me).

This exercise includes two elements: 1. practicing reciprocal empathy and 2. building emotional intimacy. Completing the below will will help you take emotional risks, break destructive cycles and open up new communication.

PART 1

DIRECTIONS: You can do this exercise alone, or in conversation with your partner. Answer the questions below, focusing on either emotional vulnerabilities or sexual vulnerabilities.

1. *What is one vulnerability that you would say your partner struggles with?*

2. *How do you see the way that he or she grapples with that vulnerability?*

3. *How have you been helpful or not towards his or her vulnerability?*

For example:

1. She struggles with poor body image.
2. She tries to exercise and to eat better but she often lacks motivation.
3. I have been quite critical and have been picking at her, so I guess I have not been particularly helpful to say the least.

OR

1. One vulnerability my boyfriend struggles with is lack of confidence.
2. He often feels overlooked and short changed.
3. I try and boost his ego, and often my attempts are helpful, but there are also times when we fight that I tell him that without me he would be nowhere.

Mapping Our Erotic Blueprint Conversation #7: Trust, Empathy & Emotional Intimacy

Relating to your partner's vulnerability is a way to see them for who they are, separately from you and separately from their affect on you. More important than apologizing is to be accountable, to state the facts from the perspective of the other. You need not agree with your partner's point of view, but you should acknowledge theirs is a valid point of view.

PART 2 RECIPROCAL EMPATHY
Time required: 10 minutes

STEP 1.
Sit facing each other. One person will be the Speaker, the other the Listener then you will switch.

STEP 2.
Make eye contact. Eye contact is known to help in any conflict resolution

STEP 3.
Speaker says to listener: " I want to talk about a time when I fell short for you, when I wasn't there the way you needed me to, when I let you down. I want to acknowledge this and I would like to take responsibility for my actions." Pick one situation , only one. Mine it deeply and truthfully.

STEP 4.
Listener, just say thanks. It means much to me to hear you say this. Pick your own words, but the point is you say thanks, I hear you, and not more. No qualifications, disqualifications, editorial improvements please. Can you hear it and receive it? Or are you stuck in the complaint and the criticism.